

Nodding along doesn't mean it landed

8 findings · 13-step checklist · 1 myth · 6 sources · [cheatgrid.com](#)

You keep going because stopping to check feels riskier than not knowing. **A nod like that takes almost no effort to produce,** whether or not anything is actually landing.

THE GOAL

You're trying to find out whether it actually landed, not just whether they look like it did. Ask for one part back in their own words.

CHECKLIST

You're mid-explanation, they've gone quiet and are nodding, and you're about to just keep going.

- ☐ Finish the sentence you're on, then stop there instead of moving straight to the next point.
- ☐ Pick the one part of what you just said that matters most for what they do next.
- ☐ If more than one person is listening and only some are nodding, check the quietest one, not the group.
- ☐ **Frame it around your explanation**, not their attention, before you ask anything.
- ☐ **Ask for that one part back**, in their own words: "What would you tell someone else, in a sentence?"
- ☐ Wait for the whole answer before you react, even if the first few words sound off.
- ☐ If they ask a question while you're checking, answer it fully before you go back to the check.
- ☐ If they say it back correctly, name the next point and move on.
- ☐ If they get part of it right, point to the exact word or step that was off, and explain just that piece a different way.
- ☐ If they get it wrong or go blank, drop the explanation you just gave and try a concrete example instead.
- ☐ After you re-explain, ask for that same part back again before you move on.
- ☐ If you're short on time, get just that one part confirmed before you end, rather than skip the check.
- ☐ Before you switch to a new topic, ask for one line that ties the whole explanation together.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** You still think you got through even when someone didn't follow, and you're **wrong close to half the time.**
- 2** **Asking someone to prove they understood can land as an accusation.**
- 3** Reteach or adjust just the part that didn't land, instead of repeating the whole explanation.

What that nod actually proves

KNOW

You still think you got through even when someone didn't follow, and you're **wrong close to half the time.**

People watching someone else's explanation from outside don't make this mistake, so it seems tied to judging your own words. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

People can tune out and keep nodding along without you catching it. The nodding looks the same either way. Nodding, eye contact and smiling looked the same in every condition, and only more frequent interrupting gave feigning away. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Even people coached on exactly what to watch for could barely tell who was really listening.

The observers had been shown exactly which behaviors to watch for beforehand, and still landed close to guessing at random. [Source 2](#)

Why they might not even know it isn't landing

KNOW

Someone who's lost usually doesn't know it themselves. When patients were checked right after a hospital visit, the confused ones noticed it only one time in five.

In that same check, roughly four confused people out of five had no idea they'd missed anything. [Source 3](#)

DON'T

Asking someone to prove they understood can land as an accusation.

People raised this themselves: sprung with no warning, it can feel less like curiosity and more like a test. [Source 4](#)

SAY

Say the reason before you ask: "I want to make sure I explained that clearly." Then ask for it back.

Naming your own explanation as what's being checked, not their understanding, was the reframe people said would land better. [Source 4](#)

What actually tells you, and what to do with it

DO

Looking or sounding like they followed doesn't confirm they did. **What actually rules that out is hearing them say part of it back, in words that are theirs.**

People often say or act like they understood even when they didn't, from false confidence or reluctance to admit confusion. [Source 5](#)

DO

Reteach or adjust just the part that didn't land, instead of repeating the whole explanation.

The check shows exactly where understanding is missing, so you can reteach that part instead of everything. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

If you ask "do you understand?" and they say yes, that settles it.

ACTUALLY

People say yes to that question whether or not it's true, so a yes answers nothing. **The only real test is hearing it back in their own words.** [Source 5](#)

Sources

1. <https://mdl.uchicago.edu/research/keysar-2002-speakers-overestimation-of-their-effectiveness.pdf>
2. https://hannekcollins.weebly.com/uploads/1/4/5/2/145205847/conveying_and_detecting_listening_in_live_conversation.pdf
3. <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/18619710/>
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5. <https://www.ahrq.gov/teamstepps-program/curriculum/communication/tools/teachback.html>
6. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC6590951/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Explaining something complicated at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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